

This is a great question to scrutinize critically, because this instruction is a significant red flag from a design principles standpoint.

Critical Assessment

The short answer: this is one of the worst candidates for a text instruction. It violates multiple Databricks best practices simultaneously.

What's Wrong With It

1. It's teaching join logic via text — SQL is far more reliable.

Databricks is explicit: prioritize SQL expressions and example SQL over text instructions. Structured definitions through SQL are more reliable and maintainable than plain text guidance. [Microsoft Learn](#) This instruction is essentially a SQL query written in prose. Genie now has to parse natural language to reconstruct join logic it should simply be shown.

2. It's too long and too specific to be a reliable text instruction.

Genie spaces perform best with a limited, focused set of instructions. Too many instructions can reduce effectiveness, especially in longer conversations, because Genie might struggle to prioritize the most important guidance. [Databricks](#) This single instruction is dense enough to overwhelm context in a long conversation, and it touches multiple concerns at once: join type, COALESCE logic, lookup table joining, and a date filter.

3. It's describing complexity that almost certainly means the data model needs fixing upstream.

The very existence of this instruction is a signal. If correctly answering participation questions requires a LEFT JOIN with a specific COALESCE pattern across five columns, that complexity should not be hidden in a text prompt — it should be **eliminated at the data layer**.

